

Chapter 186 Part 1: Extra Story 9-1

(Timeline does not overlap with previous chapter)

Another winter had arrived.

The snow fell late this year, but when it came, it was heavy—as if making up for all the previous deficit.

The snow began falling at midnight, and by morning, a thick layer had accumulated, almost reaching ankle height.

Approaching noon, there was still no sign of it stopping.

Chaochao and Mumu had started boarding at school once they entered high school. They only needed to be picked up from school at 6 PM when they had their weekly break.

So Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were finally having their world of two again after many years.

Because of the heavy snow, Xu Qingzhu didn't go out to work and handled some matters in the study.

Liang Shi had also just finished filming a drama and was in her rest period. She read for a while in the living room, and as mealtime approached, the two of them tacitly agreed to have hot pot.

To better enjoy the scenery, the two moved their dining spot to the balcony.

Outside the huge floor-to-ceiling windows, white snow drifted down. The entire world was wrapped in silver, appearing beautiful and serene.

Liang Shi neatly arranged the delivered food, then went to the kitchen to prepare two bowls of dipping sauce.

She had originally planned to just put the hot pot base directly in to cook, but after taking out the hot pot base, she felt it wasn't quite right. Driven by her perfectionism, she went and stir-fried the base first, and the fragrance of hot pot immediately filled the house.

There was no heating on the balcony, so Liang Shi brought two blankets, and also cracked the window open a small gap.

The steamy heat dissipated outward with the wind.

An ordinary hot pot meal became extraordinary because of this heavy snow.

Liang Shi also opened a very expensive bottle of wine from the wine cabinet.

By the time Xu Qingzhu came out of the study, everything was ready.

The atmosphere was perfect.

Xu Qingzhu sat in the rattan chair and accidentally reclined all the way back, laughing as she teased: "How am I supposed to eat like this?"

"I'll get you a different chair." Liang Shi stood up, but Xu Qingzhu didn't want that and got up herself to switch to one from the living room.

With just the two of them at home, both familiar with each other's eating habits, they ate in perfect sync.

After eating and drinking their fill, the two switched to the rattan chairs and sat on the balcony watching the snow.

Snowflakes drifted and swirled, like feathers fluttering through the air.

Xu Qingzhu rested with her eyes half-closed, suddenly saying with emotion: "It seems like Haizhou City hasn't had such heavy snow in a long time."

"Is that so?" Liang Shi agreed, "I don't recall seeing such heavy snow either."

Although Haizhou City was in the north, it didn't get much precipitation. In winter, there would occasionally be some snow, but never this heavy.

At least Liang Shi hadn't seen anything like it in all these years.

"The last time I saw snow this heavy was when I was in university." Xu Qingzhu said: "I remember almost freezing my calves off going to the supermarket to buy things."

Liang Shi laughed softly: "Then why did you still go?"

"To see the snow, I suppose."

After saying this, Xu Qingzhu dozed off with her eyes closed, her breathing gradually becoming even.

The temperature inside was just right, and the scenery outside was beautiful. Listening to Xu Qingzhu's even breathing, Liang Shi also slowly drifted off to sleep.

The white snow blurred her vision. Liang Shi felt herself falling into an environment full of thick fog and white snow.

She reached out her hand but couldn't see it—she could only feel the icy coldness.

Liang Shi withdrew her hand.

Then the thick fog dispersed, white was replaced by color, and this colorful world appeared.

But this world was also a blanket of white, because of the heavy snow.

The snow had fallen extremely thick, already past people's calves.

Someone lay motionless face-down in the snow, as if they had fainted. Liang Shi walked up to her and reached out to help her up, but her hand passed through the person's body.

The person seemed to be dead, and everyone passing by kept their distance.

Liang Shi called out: "Wake up."

Only the echo of her own voice reached her ears.

The other person couldn't hear her speak.

Liang Shi looked around and slowly recognized the place—this was Qingyi University.

Many of the surrounding buildings were covered in white snow, and they were more worn than the current Qingyi University, so it wasn't immediately recognizable.

Passersby came and went.

Liang Shi couldn't actually feel the cold, but seeing the sky full of white snow, she unconsciously rubbed her arms.

After quite a while, a girl wearing a white down jacket and white scarf passed by that "corpse." After walking past, she suddenly stopped, slowly turned around, thought for two seconds, then walked back and placed the cup of milk tea in her hand near the "corpse."

The moment the milk tea was set down, the snow immediately melted in a ring around it.

The girl's voice was very low, and Liang Shi couldn't hear what she said.

But after the girl left, that "corpse" suddenly sat up, face covered in snow, features indiscernible.

She stared at the girl's retreating figure for a long time, then raised her hand and brushed her face, clearing away all the snow to reveal that face.

It was a face identical to Liang Shi's.

She held the milk tea in her palm, poked it open and took a sip, then suddenly smiled.

Liang Shi followed her figure as she left Qingyi University, and heard that detestable voice again.

Qiu Zimin said on the phone: "A-Shi, come home to stay."

After returning, that room was dark, stuffy, suffocating.

And in the unlit room, with just a pencil, she drew the graceful figure she had seen during the day.

Especially that smile.

A smile that was shy yet carried a hint of sunshine.

Light and shadow shifted.

The surroundings suddenly turned white, but then quickly changed again.

In a piano room, someone sat backlit, playing the piano.

She wore a white shirt, her black hair reaching her shoulders. Above the piano room flowed her music, gentle as water.